

The Identity of Dhū al-Qarnayn and a Response to Alleged Alexander Parallels

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Dhū al-Qarnayn, who appears in Sūrat al-Kahf 83-98, is often linked to Alexander the Great, and is brought up against Islam, as an example of a plagiarized legend. The connection is considered especially problematic since Dhū al-Qarnayn is portrayed in the Quran as a monotheistic servant of God, while Alexander was known historically as a pagan. The claim that Alexander was pagan is generally accepted by historians since his classical biographies portray him as such.¹

This article includes a response that provides the earliest Islamic conclusions surrounding the identity of Dhū al-Qarnayn, a response to some highlighted parallels, and a brief discussion concerning the dating of texts that are brought forward as sources of the Quran.

The Earliest Islamic Identification of Dhū al-Qarnayn

While drawing connections by examining parallels is the standard methodology to determine the reliance of sources upon each other, the characteristics of Dhū al-Qarnayn according to the earliest Muslims conflict with what we know of both Alexander's history and how he was portrayed in legends. Hence, before even examining the parallels and dating texts, it is imperative to provide a brief background according to reliable Islamic traditions.

The episode starts with the Quranic passage that states: "And they ask you about Dhū al-Qarnayn," suggesting that the Prophet (peace be upon him) is tested with knowledge of an ancient personality. The Quran provides elaborate details concerning his journey, his conversations, and actions, all while avoiding directly naming him. Instead, the Quran sticks to the title "Dhū al-Qarnayn" in multiple passages. He is referred to by Quraysh (Q 18:83), those who sought his support (Q. 18:94), and by Allah the Exalted himself (Q. 18:86) with the same

¹ Arrian, *The Landmark Arrian: The Campaigns of Alexander*, pp. 102, 126.

title. If Dhū al-Qarnayn was meant to be Alexander, it would have been more fitting to mention his name in response, to display knowledge of the identity of Alexander. One can conclude that the Quran is avoiding the name while affirming the title, suggesting it was better established than the name. Despite the two-horned iconography, Alexander was not commonly known to hold this title.

In al-Tījān, by Wahb bin Munabbih, Ibn ‘Abbās is asked directly about the identity of Dhū al-Qarnayn. He affirmed that he was the Himyarite king al-Ṣa‘b bin Dhī Marāthid, differentiating him from Alexander, while praising the latter as a good and wise “Roman.” Wahb then reports from Ka‘b al-Aḥbār: “The correct position in our view, which is based on our Rabbis and predecessors, is that he [Dhū al-Qarnayn] is from Ḥimyar, and it is al-Ṣa‘b bin Dhī Marāthid, and Alexander is a man from the sons of **Yunān** bin ‘Īṣ bin Ishāq bin Ibrāhīm, and his people met Jesus the son of Mary...” The “people of Yunān” is how the Arabs would refer to the Greeks.² Ka‘b obviously erred in some of the information provided about Alexander, but it is sufficient for us that he considers al-Ṣa‘b bin Dhī Marāthid as Dhū al-Qarnayn, while also confirming that this is the view of his Rabbis and predecessors.

Ka‘b al-Aḥbār was a Himyarite and a Jewish convert to Islam. The Himyarites had been Jewish for centuries before Islam.³ This is significant because it is believed that those who posed the question about Dhū al-Qarnayn were Madinan Jews.⁴ So, it is reasonable to assume that Himyarite Jews would have a good idea about Dhū al-Qarnayn’s identity, especially if he was a Himyarite as well.

The view that Dhū al-Qarnayn was al-Ṣa‘b is further supported by the poetry of Labīd bin Rabī‘a.⁵ Ibn Ḥajar leaned towards this opinion and listed out several pre-Islamic poets who referred to al-Ṣa‘b as Dhū al-Qarnayn, including Aws bin Ḥajar, Ṭarafa, al-Rabī‘ bin Ḍubay‘, as well as others.⁶

The title Dhū al-Qarnayn is sometimes translated as the “two-horned one” and since Alexander iconography displays him with two ram horns, critics conclude that he must be Dhū al-Qarnayn. However, the earliest explanation of the name of Dhū al-Qarnayn directly conflicts with this conclusion. ‘Alī bin Abī Ṭālib, the cousin of the Prophet (peace be upon him), explicitly stated that Dhū al-Qarnayn was someone that “did not have horns like that of a bull.”⁷ He explained that Dhū al-Qarnayn received his name by being struck on the sides of the head. He was sent to his people, to call them to guidance. He was struck on one side of his head (*qarn*), resurrected by God, then struck on the other side of his head. Because of these two strikes to the sides of the

² Ibn Munabbih, *al-Tījān fī Mulūk Ḥimyar*, pp. 119-120.

³ ‘Alī, *al-Mufaṣṣal fī Tārīkh al-‘Arab Qabl al-Islām*, 6/420-422.

⁴ Ibn Hishām, *al-Sīrah al-Nabawīyyah*, 1/283.

⁵ Ibn Ḥabīb, *al-Muḥabbar*, p. 365.

⁶ Ibn Ḥajar, *Fath al-Bārī*, 6/464-465.

⁷ Al-Ṣan‘ānī, *Tafsīr ‘Abd al-Razzāq*, 3/234-235.

head, he earned the name Dhū al-Qarnayn.⁸ The word *qarnayn* is the dual form of *qarn*. Such a description is missing from both the histories and legends of Alexander, which would indicate that Dhū al-Qarnayn is someone else. Furthermore, ‘Alī clearly was not familiar with the Alexander iconography, where Alexander is portrayed as a two-horned ram. It would have been more fitting for ‘Alī to say: “Dhū al-Qarnayn did not have horns like that of a ram,” if he connected the iconography to Dhū al-Qarnayn.

Furthermore, it is also likelier for ‘Alī to be familiar with the iconography than the Prophet (peace be upon him) since this narration occurred during his caliphate in Kūfa, after the split with the Harurites in 657 CE, as the report references them.⁹ The utterance occurred at least 35 years after the revelation of the Makkan Sūrat al-Kahf. In other words, if ‘Alī wasn’t aware of the connection while in Kūfa, then it is highly improbable that his cousin (peace be upon him) knew of it before 35 years earlier in Makkah. Sūrat al-Kahf was revealed before the migration to Madinah, during the Makkan period (610 – 622 CE). The dating of Sūrat al-Kahf is quite straightforward. The chapter was revealed in Makkah, according to the companions of the Prophet (peace be upon him), like Ibn Mas‘ūd, Ibn ‘Abbās, and Ibn al-Zubayr, as well as second generation Muslim scholars like al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī, ‘Ikrimah, ‘Atā’, Jābir bin Zayd, and Mujāhid.¹⁰ Ibn Mas‘ūd specifically listed it among the earliest revealed chapters that he memorized.¹¹ The early dating for Sūrat al-Kahf is an obstacle for van Bladel who proposes that the Muslims may have heard of the story of the Legend during the Battle of Mu’ta in 629 CE.¹²

Another interpretation for the title Dhū al-Qarnayn is “one with two braids,” as was the case of al-Mundir bin Mā’ al-Samā’, the king of al-Ḥīra.¹³ The classical Makkan scholar, ‘Atā’, casually referred to those that form their hair into two braids as “Dhū al-Qarnayn,” instructing men to avoid lowering their braids onto their backs, but to dangle them in the front instead.¹⁴ Alexander iconography does not have him displayed with two braids. With these points in mind, one can conclude that the translation of Dhū al-Qarnayn to the “two-horned one” is merely an assumption, and that it is not attested to by the earliest Islamic authorities or traditions.

It needs to be mentioned that some early Muslims did consider Dhū al-Qarnayn to be Alexander, like Ibn Hishām, the author of the *sīrah*. Strangely, Ibn Hishām also presented a report from Khālīd bin Ma’dān al-Kilā’ī, the Levantine jurist from Ḥimṣ, who attributed to ‘Umar bin al-Khaṭṭāb that Dhū al-Qarnayn was the name of an angel.¹⁵ Alexander was not an angel. The Levantine jurist, who passed away in 721 CE, despite having greater access to Syriac texts than his predecessors, did not recognize the parallels between Dhū al-Qarnayn and Alexander, when

⁸ Ibn Abī Shaybah, *al-Muṣannaḥ*, 6/349.

⁹ Al-Ṣan‘ānī, *Tafsīr ‘Abd al-Razzāq*, 3/235.

¹⁰ Al-Fāleḥ, *al-Makkī wal-Madanī min al-Suwar wal-Āyāt*, pp. 84-87.

¹¹ Al-Bukhārī, *Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī*, p. 825.

¹² Van Bladel, “The Alexander Legend in the Quran 18:83-102”, p. 190.

¹³ Al-Ṭabarī, *Tārīkh al-Ṭabarī*, 1/253.

¹⁴ Al-Ṣan‘ānī, *al-Muṣannaḥ*, 2/83.

¹⁵ Ibn Hishām, *al-Sīrah al-Nabawīyyah*, 1/288-289.

narrating that Dhū al-Qarnayn was an angel. Ironically, a report by ‘Alī included a denial that Dhū al-Qarnayn was an angel.¹⁶

Other early reports also clearly conflict with the identification of Alexander as Dhū al-Qarnayn. For example, the first century Makkah scholar ‘Ubayd bin ‘Umayr, or his son, stated that Dhū al-Qarnayn met Ibrāhīm (peace be upon him) during the pilgrimage.¹⁷ On a similar note, Ibn Ḥajar concluded that al-Bukhārī included Dhū al-Qarnayn in a chapter before the prophets of Banū Isrā’īl to indicate that he predated them.¹⁸ If al-Bukhārī had considered Dhū al-Qarnayn to be Alexander, he would have placed him several chapters later, after the prophets of Banū Isrā’īl but before Zakarīyyā and ‘Īsā (may Allah be pleased with them).

As for prophetic reports, there only appears to be one authentic narration, in which the Prophet (peace be upon him) simply stated, “I do not know if Dhū al-Qarnayn was a prophet or not.”¹⁹ While this may not seem to mean much, we can conclude that the Prophet (peace be upon him) did not have access to texts about Alexander, like the Syriac Legend, that clearly portray Alexander as a prophet, who actually prophesied events, was literally visited by God, and was supported by Him during war.²⁰

Another reason why the Prophet (peace be upon him) could not have depended on the Syriac Legend is because Sūrat al-Kahf predates it. However, there are other sources that predate the Quran that are often brought up when the Dhū al-Qarnayn – Alexander connection is made.

Pre-Islamic Parallels

Critics of the Quran who claim that Dhū al-Qarnayn refers to Alexander often reference pre-Islamic works that speak of a gate that was built by the latter in order to make the connection.

Josephus, in the Wars of the Jews, stated:

Now there was a nation of the Alans, which we have formerly mentioned somewhere as being Scythians, and inhabiting at the lake Meotis. This nation, about this time, laid a design of falling upon Media and the parts beyond it, in order to plunder them; with which intention they treated with the king of Hyrcania; for he was master of that passage **which King Alexander [the Great] shut up with iron gates.** This king gave them leave to come through them; so

¹⁶ Ibn Abī Shaybah, *al-Muṣannaf*, 6/349.

¹⁷ Ibn ‘Asākir, *Tārīkh Dimashq*, 9/571-572.

¹⁸ Ibn Ḥajar, *Fath al-Bārī*, 6/462.

¹⁹ Al-Nīsāpūrī, *al-Mustadrak ‘alā al-Ṣaḥīḥayn*, 4/1379-1380.

²⁰ Pseudo-Callisthenes, *The History of Alexander the Great*, pp. 154-156.

they came in great multitudes, and fell upon the Medes unexpectedly, and plundered their country... So the Alans, being still more provoked by this sight, laid waste the country, and drove a great multitude of the men, and a great quantity of the other prey they had gotten out of both kingdoms, along with them, and then retreated back to their own country.²¹

One should be cautious and avoid reading into the text what it does not include.

The Quran states that Dhū al-Qarnayn built a wall against Gog and Magog. Alexander, here, did not build a wall, but he built a gate. The gate was not built to keep the Alans away either, let alone seal them. All the text mentions is Alexander built a gate, as kings and commanders did in classical times. Gates provide controlled access and are used for taxing entrants. The Alans, centuries after Alexander, were allowed by the king of Hyrcania to access the gates, which they turned into an opportunity to attack and plunder. The very fact that they were allowed to pass freely, after requesting permission, suggests that the gate wasn't built with them in mind.

Dhū al-Qarnayn, on the other hand, did not build a gate, but he built a wall, with the specific purpose of sealing away Gog and Magog.

The Quran states: "He responded, 'What my Lord has provided for me is far better. But assist me with resources, and I will build a barrier between you and them. Bring me blocks of iron!' Then, when he had filled up 'the gap' between the two mountains, he ordered, 'Blow!' When the iron became red hot, he said, 'Bring me molten copper to pour over it.' And so the enemies could neither scale nor tunnel through it."²²

The description does not match a gate that provides controlled access. Procopius, in his description of the gate, mentioned that detours can be made to get around it,²³ while the Syriac Alexander Legend goes as far as to describe how the hinged gate was designed to swing.²⁴ These descriptions oppose the Quran's barrier that is built with the purpose of sealing a nation.

A second attempt at connecting Alexander's gate with Dhū al-Qarnayn's wall is derived from another text by Josephus, his *Antiquities of the Jews*. In it, he stated that the Scythians are referred to by Greeks as Magogites.²⁵

By combining both quotes, proponents of the theory conclude that the Alans are the Scythians, who happen to be Magogites, and Alexander built a **gate** to seal them away. Of course, Josephus never said that the gate was built with the Alans in mind, let alone the Scythians or the

²¹ Josephus, *The Works of Flavius Josephus*, p. 870.

²² Q. 18:95-97

²³ Procopius, *History of the Wars*, 1/79.

²⁴ Pseudo-Callisthenes, *The History of Alexander the Great*, p. 153.

²⁵ Josephus, *The Works of Flavius Josephus*, p. 47.

Magogites. Josephus, when speaking about the Alans in the Wars of the Jews doesn't even refer to them as Magogites.

Andrew Anderson correctly pointed out that “there is no indication that these elements have been put together in the time of Josephus, or, if put together, that they had gained general acceptance; for if they had, the later variations in interpretation of the terms Gog and Magog would hardly have come into being.”²⁶ Anderson listed multiple nations that had been linked with Gog and Magog in classical texts, demonstrating that the Alans – Magogite connection was not made.²⁷ Hence, through Josephus alone, the most that can be obtained as a parallel would simply be: Alexander built a gate and Dhū al-Qarnayn built a wall.

Even if we considered the gate and the wall to be one and the same, the motif is too broad to be considered a notable parallel. Had there been a dragon placed at the front by both Alexander and Dhū al-Qarnayn, an actual argument could be made.

Three centuries after Josephus (d. 100 CE), Jerome (d. 420 CE) briefly mentioned Alexander's gate in passing. He said: “We were told that swarms of Huns had poured forth from the distant Sea of Azov, midway between the icy river Tanais and the savage tribes of Massagetae, where the gates of Alexander keep back the barbarians behind the rocky Caucasus.”²⁸

Then, after Jerome, Procopius (d. 565 CE) provided more details:

Now if these Huns go through the gate which I have just mentioned into the land of the Persians and the Romans, they come with their horses fresh and without making any detour or encountering any precipitous places, except in those fifty stades over which, as has been said, they pass to the boundary of Iberia. If however, they go by any other passes, they reach their destination with great difficulty, and can no longer use the same horses. For the detours which they are forced to make are many and steep besides. When this was observed by Alexander, the son of Philip, he constructed gates in the aforesaid place and established a fortress there. And this was held by many men in turn as time went on, and finally by Ambazouces, a Hun by birth, but a friend of the Romans and the Emperor Anastasius.²⁹

Like Josephus, Jerome and Procopius don't connect the gate of Alexander to Gog and Magog. The connection didn't even exist in texts as late as the fifth and sixth centuries. According to

²⁶ Anderson, *Alexander's Gate*, p. 20n1.

²⁷ Anderson, *Alexander's Gate*, pp. 12-14.

²⁸ Jerome, *Select Letters of St. Jerome*, p. 329.

²⁹ Procopius, *History of the Wars*, 1/79.

Emeri van Donzel and Andrea Schmidt, the first time Alexander's gate emerges to ward off Gog and Magog occurs in the Syriac Alexander Legend,³⁰ which deserves a deeper examination.

Late Parallels

Claims of parallels between the Quran and the Syriac Alexander Legend are massively exaggerated by critics, which is why it is recommended for those who assume the existence of parallels to examine the text for themselves,³¹ instead of trusting the claims without verification. Take for example the following description:

Alexander said, "Who are the nations within this mountain upon which we are looking?....." The natives of the land said, "They are the Huns." He said to them, "Who are their kings?" The old men said: "**Gog and Magog and Nawal the kings of the sons of Japhet**; and Gig and Teamron, and Tiyamron, and Beth-Gamli and Yapho'bar, and Shumardak, and Glusika, and Ekshaphar, and Salgaddo, and Nislik, and Amarphil, and Ka'ozza, these are the kings of the Huns." Alexander said, "What is their appearance, and their clothing, and their languages?" The old men answered and said to the king: "Some of them have blue eyes, and their women have but one breast apiece; and the women fight more than the men, for they wound a man with knives. They hang knives upon their thighs and arms and necks, so that, if one of them should get into a fight, wherever she stretches out her hand she can lay hold of a knife. They wear dressed skins; and they eat the raw flesh of everything which dies of theirs; and they drink the blood of men and of animals..."³²

Observe how Gog and Magog are portrayed as two kings, among many, instead of a nation. If the Quran was borrowing from the Syriac Legend, one would expect it to refer to the Huns as a whole, instead of the first two kings from a list of fifteen. The portrayal of this nation's warriors as single-breasted female warriors is also absent from Islamic sources.

Taha Soomro deconstructed the commonly cited parallels, like the alleged fetid sea parallel, the building of the swinging gate, and the alleged linguistic similarities.³³ Some of these parallels are in fact contradictions. Soomro noted that the Legend speaks of cave dwellers that escaped the sun into their caves, while the Quran spoke of people with no protection from the sun,³⁴ implying

³⁰ Van Donzel and Schmidt, *Gog and Magog in Early Syriac and Islamic Sources*, p. 17.

³¹ Pseudo-Callisthenes, *The History of Alexander the Great*, pp. 144-159.

³² Pseudo-Callisthenes, *The History of Alexander the Great*, pp. 150-151.

³³ Soomro, "Did the Qur'ān borrow from the Syriac Legend of Alexander?", pp. 2-3, 11-12, and 13-14.

³⁴ Soomro, "Did the Qur'ān borrow from the Syriac Legend of Alexander?", p. 11n1.

that they lived in a flat land. Soomro, furthermore, made an argument for linguistic dissimilarity, listing out Syriac words with an Arabic cognate, and how the Quran avoids using them, proving that it did not depend on the Syriac Legend.³⁵

Most academics recognize that the Syriac Legend can be dated to 628 CE at the earliest due to its *vaticinium ex eventu*, which predicted certain events. Despite Tesei's reservations, the dating of the Legend to the time of Heraclius is the "scholarly consensus."³⁶ The specific text in question, from the Syriac Legend, goes as follows:

And king Alexander fetched [an engraver] and inscribed upon the gate: "The Huns shall go forth and conquer the countries of the Romans and of the Persians, and shall cast arrows with....., and shall return and enter their own land. **Also I have written that, at the conclusion of eight hundred and twenty-six years, the Huns shall go forth by the narrow way which goes forth opposite Halôrâs, whence the Tigris goes forth like the stream which turns a mill, and they shall take captive the nations, and shall cut off the roads, and shall make the earth tremble by their going forth. And again I have written and made known and prophesied that it shall come to pass, at the conclusion of nine hundred and forty years,..... another king, when the world shall come to an end by the command of God the ruler of creation.** Created things shall anger God, and sin shall increase, and wrath shall reign, and the sins of mankind shall mount up and shall cover the heavens, and the Lord will stir up in His anger the kingdoms that lie within this gate; for when the Lord seeks to slay men, he sends men against men, and they destroy one another. And the Lord will gather together the kings and their hosts which are within this mountain, and they shall all be assembled at His beck, and shall come with their spears and swords, and shall stand behind the gate, and shall look up to the heavens, and shall call upon the name of the Lord, saying, 'O Lord, open to us this gate' And the Lord shall send His sign from heaven and a voice shall call on this gate, and it shall be destroyed and fall at the beck of the Lord, and it shall not be opened by the key which I have made for it. And a troop shall go through this gate which I have made, and a full span shall be worn away from the lower threshold by the hoofs of the horses which with their riders shall go forth to destroy the land by the command of the Lord; and a span shall be worn away from the upper threshold by the points of the spears of those that shall run over it and go forth. And when the Huns have gone forth, as God has commanded, the kingdoms of the Huns and the Persians and the Arabs, the twenty-four kingdoms that are written in this book, shall come from the ends of the heavens and shall fall upon one another, and the earth shall melt through the blood and dung of men. Then the kingdom of the Greeks shall move

³⁵ Soomro, "Did the Qur'ân borrow from the Syriac Legend of Alexander?", pp. 18-19.

³⁶ Tesei, *The Syriac Legend of Alexander's Gate*, p. 2.

itself, and shall come and take a hammer of iron in its right hand, and a hammer of brass in its left, and the kingdom of Greece shall smite the hammers one upon the other, and as iron which is melted by fire, and as brass which boils in the flame, so shall the power of the kingdoms melt away before the might of the kingdom of the Greeks which is that of the Romans. And the kingdoms of the Huns and of the Persians shall be desolated the one by the other; only a few of them shall escape who shall flee to their country; and what remains of them the kingdom of the Romans shall destroy.”³⁷

The first of the two prophecies is identified as the invasion of the nomadic Sabirs of Syria and Anatolia in 514-515 CE. The second coincides with Heraclius’ victory against the Sassanids with the support of Türks in 628 CE.³⁸

According to Reinink:

The readers of the story should consider the events of old as being repeated in their own days and thus recognize the special place of the Greek-Byzantine empire in God’s history of salvation, from the very beginning of this empire until the end of time, when this empire will acquire world-dominion. With that object in view, the author created an Alexander-Heraclius typology, in which the image of Alexander is highly determined by Byzantine imperial ideology. Alexander becomes the classical example of the ideal Christian emperor, who considers and fulfils his wordly task in conformity with God’s will and with God’s assistance.³⁹

Reinink stated that “we may assume that the Alexander Legend was composed about 630, when Heraclius’ pilgrimage to the Holy City was most immediately relevant,”⁴⁰ but in theory, the time of composition could extend to the end of Heraclius’ reign in 641 CE. Since the kingdom of the Arabs is mentioned in the prophecy, it is likelier that the text was written when they became politically relevant as opponents of the Byzantines. The prophecy would not be referring to Ghassanids that were the vassals of the Byzantines, nor would it be referring to the Lakhmids that were the vassals of the Sassanids. In fact, the Sassanids would sometimes appoint a Persian to rule al-Ḥīra.⁴¹ The Arabs only became a serious threat to the Byzantines in the year 634 CE during the Islamic expansions.

Based on the aforementioned datings, *Sūrat al-Kahf* (610 – 622 CE) predates the Syriac Alexander Legend (630 CE – 641 CE) by at least a decade, but with the possibility of it extending to almost three decades.

³⁷ Pseudo-Callisthenes, *The History of Alexander the Great*, pp. 154-155.

³⁸ Van Bladel, “The Alexander Legend in the Quran 18:83-102”, pp. 183-184.

³⁹ Reinink, “Alexander the Great in 7th Century Syriac ‘Apocalyptic’ texts”, p. 162

⁴⁰ Reinink, “Alexander the Great in 7th Century Syriac ‘Apocalyptic’ texts”, p. 165

⁴¹ Saqr, *Tārīkh Mamlakat al-Manāḍira*, pp. 57, 68-69.

Not surprisingly, some Western academics dismiss the second prophecy in the text as an interpolation, in order to push for an earlier date. Tesei argued that “the original text of Alexander’s prophecy must have included *only one prediction ex eventu*.”⁴² His conclusions are not based on tangible evidence one would expect, like manuscripts without the alleged “interpolation,” but he instead highlighted narrative inconsistencies and issues with sentence structure.⁴³ This highlights one of the difficulties of dating pseudepigrapha that are written centuries after the events in question. Not only are the interpretations of the internal evidence for dating very speculative, but the key passages that are used for dating can easily be dismissed.

Regardless, dismissing the 940 prophecy opens the door to dismissing other parts of the text too, such as the alleged parallels that are considered to be an influence upon the Quran. After all, the earliest extant manuscript of the Syriac Alexander Legend only dates to the 18th century,⁴⁴ which allows for centuries of interpolations. After all, the likelihood of late interpolations into the text far outweighs the possibility of the Legend influencing the Quran. As stated in the first section of this article, the Prophet (peace be upon him) didn’t even know whether Dhū al-Qarnayn was a prophet or not.

Take for example van Bladel’s observation regarding the Quran’s “We shall leave them on that day surging like waves against each other” and the Syriac Legend’s “and kingdoms will fall upon each other.”⁴⁵ If one assumed that this was indeed an example of borrowing, then one should assume that it occurred at the hands of a Syriac scribe since it is only present in one of the five manuscripts, as Soomro observed, which would suggest that it is a late insertion.⁴⁶ There is no reason that this could not extend to the other alleged parallels.

While the Syriac Legend is the main source that is presented when attempting to display parallels, there are other sources that also are used that seem to have been written even later.

This includes the Alexander Poem, which has a *terminus ante quem* of 640 CE according to Reinink, since the date coincides with Arabian invasions of Syria and Mesopotamia.⁴⁷ Reinink explained that it was clearly written as a response to the Syriac Alexander Legend, since the opening of the gate leads to a glorious future for Alexander’s empire, while the Alexander Poem predicts that it leads to the destruction of the empire instead.⁴⁸

Critics will also sometimes point to parallels in Pseudo-Callisthenes’ Alexander Romance, due to the early 3rd century dating, while avoiding specifying which recension of the text they are referring to.

⁴² Tesei, *The Syriac Legend of Alexander’s Gate*, p. 44.

⁴³ Tesei, *The Syriac Legend of Alexander’s Gate*, pp. 30-44.

⁴⁴ Pseudo-Callisthenes, *The History of Alexander the Great*, p. xv.

⁴⁵ Van Bladel, “The Alexander Legend in the Quran 18:83-102”, p. 181.

⁴⁶ Soomro, “Did the Qur’ān borrow from the Syriac Legend of Alexander?”, pp. 13-14.

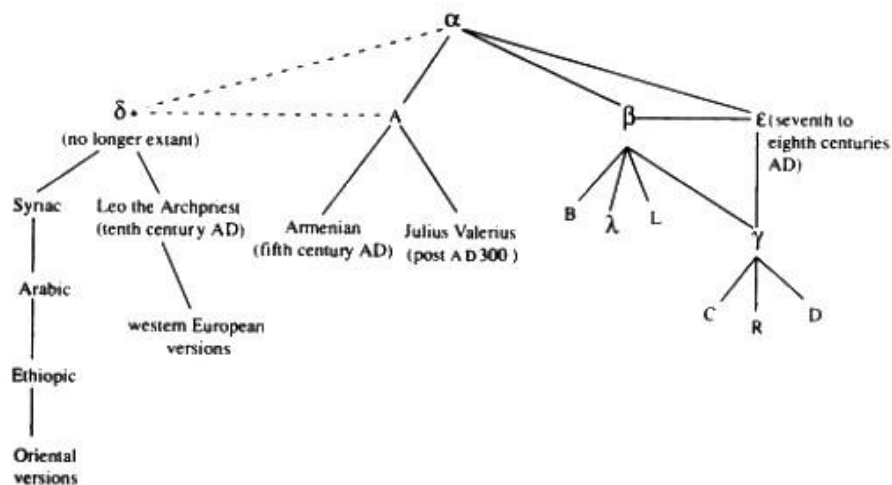
⁴⁷ Reinink, “Alexander the Great in 7th Century Syriac ‘Apocalyptic’ texts”, p. 165

⁴⁸ Reinink, “Alexander the Great in 7th Century Syriac ‘Apocalyptic’ texts”, pp. 166-167.

For example, the Greek recension of the Alexander Romance contains the following:

So Alexander shut in twenty-two kings with their subject nations behind the northern boundaries - behind the gates that he called the Caspian and the mountains known as the Breasts. These are the names of those nations: Goth, Magoth, Anougeis, Aigeis, Exenach, Diphar, Photinaioi, Pharizaioi, Zarmatianoï, Chachonioi, Agrimardoï, Anouphagoi, Tharbaioi, Alans, Physolonikaioi, Saltarioi, and the rest. These were the nations that dwelt behind the gates that King Alexander built so as to be indestructible. They used to eat worms and foul things that were not real food at all - dogs, flies, snakes, aborted foetuses, dead bodies and unformed human embryos; and they ate not only animals but the corpses of humans as well. Alexander, seeing all this, was afraid that they would come out and pollute the inhabited world; so he shut them in and went on his way.⁴⁹

However, the passage, according to Stoneman, is only found in the γ -recension of the Greek Romance.⁵⁰ The γ -recension is based on a combination of both the β and the ε -recensions. Stoneman claims that the ε -recension was compiled from multiple sources, including Pseudo-Methodius, which he dates to 640 CE.⁵¹ The γ -recension takes from the ε -recension, which pushes it likely past the eighth century, way after the compilation of the Quran. The image below, by Stoneman, illustrates the origins of the recensions:



According to Anderson, the episode of Alexander's Gate is missing from the original form of the Greek text as well as other early translations. He said, "The episode of the building of the Gate

⁴⁹ Pseudo-Callisthenes, *The Greek Alexander Romance*, pp. 185-187

⁵⁰ Pseudo-Callisthenes, *The Greek Alexander Romance*, p. 185

⁵¹ Pseudo-Callisthenes, *The Greek Alexander Romance*, p. 29. Scholars often date Pseudo-Methodius much later due to him referencing the Umayyad Empire. Refer to the Apocalypse of Pseudo-Methodius, p. 15.

by Alexander was wanting from the original form—the so-called *Recensio Vetusta*—of the Greek *Historia Alexandri* (Pseudo-Callisthenes), represented by manuscript A, and from the Latin version by Julius Valerius. It is wanting also from the Greek manuscript *Leidensis L*, from the Syrian History of Alexander, and also from the original form of the Latin version by the Archipresbyter Leo of Naples, entitled *Nativitas et Victoria Alexandri Magni Regis*.”⁵²

The earliest version of a gate built by Alexander can be found in the Armenian recension. However, it doesn’t speak of kings, tribes, or barbarians.⁵³ Anderson claims that the addition of Gog and Magog and the unclean people shut in by Alexander is likely from a Syrian source.⁵⁴

Concluding Remarks

While not an exhaustive survey of every alleged parallel, this article highlights the issues with the trend. In all cases, the classical texts need to be returned to and examined before trusting claims about parallels, which are often exaggerated.

Dating due to internal evidence will hardly ever be concrete, for internal evidence is usually speculative and incomparable to explicit statements by classical scholars. The example of the most explicit piece of internal evidence, being the 940 prophecy, was dismissed as an interpolation after all.

The identity of the Dhū al-Qarnayn will remain uncertain to us, since early Muslims differed both in his identity and characteristics. However, the classical position favors the Himyarite king al-Ṣa‘b bin Dhī Marāthid over the Alexander hypothesis. The absence of pre-Islamic texts that explicitly connect Alexander and the Magogites diminishes the tenability of the theory even further.

⁵² Anderson, *Alexander’s Gate*, pp. 33-34.

⁵³ Anderson, *Alexander’s Gate*, p. 35

⁵⁴ Anderson, *Alexander’s Gate*, p. 44.

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